How to Talk as a Family About What Mom Needs Now

One conversation to get everyone's observations on one page, starting with hers.

Your brother sees her on Sundays. You see her on Tuesdays. Each of you is describing a different part of the same week, and Mom has her own account, which nobody has asked for yet.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: put what everyone has seen in one place. It isn't for deciding anything.

Who should be there

Mom, first. Then everyone who sees her regularly or helps with anything: the one who visits on Sundays, the one who fills the pill box, the one who lives far away and phones every night. Someone who can't come can send notes ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with her, and start with a question, not a conclusion. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. [1]

- “Mom, we want to understand how things have been since you came home. What's been easy, and what's been harder?”
- “Each of us sees a different part of your week. We'd like to put it together, and we want your version first.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one shared picture. Say what it isn't for: deciding where she lives or who does what.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. What are you doing on your own right now that you want to keep doing?

2. Where would a hand be useful?

3. What has changed since the hospital that we might not have noticed?

Ask each other

1. What have you seen her do yourself this week, and when were you there?

2. What do you do for her, and how often?

3. What have you noticed that you weren't sure whether to mention?

4. Where does what you've seen differ from what she says, or from what someone else here has seen?

5. What don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Keep Mom's own account separate from what the family has observed. Where two people saw different things, write both and don't settle it. The people who assess her will want to know that Sunday and Tuesday look different.

WHAT WAS SAID OR SEEN	WHO SAID IT	WHEN THEY SAW IT	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY
“I shower fine, I just don't like doing it when nobody's home.”	Mom	This week	
Needed a hand getting up from the kitchen chair.	David	Sunday	Karen didn't see this on Tuesday

What not to decide yet

These take an assessment, and your notes are what make it a good one. Leave them open.

- Where she should live.
- Whether she is safe on her own.
- Who was right.
- Anything about her medications.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone.
- Who will take each open question to the doctor, the nurse, the pharmacist or a care consultant.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one page, with the differences left on it.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one picture now, with Mom's account at the top. The care interview takes that picture through her situation area by area so nothing important is overlooked, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?